

# Course Manual

## Academic Writing (BETA)

Department of Language, Literature and Communication  
Faculty of Humanities  
VU University Amsterdam

### 1. BASIC DETAILS

|                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Study guide link    | <a href="https://studiegids.vu.nl/nl/vakken/2024-2025/L_ETBAALG006#/L_ETBAALG006">https://studiegids.vu.nl/nl/vakken/2024-2025/L_ETBAALG006#/L_ETBAALG006</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| Course code         | L_ETBAALG006                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Period              | 5 (April-May 2025)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Course credits      | 3 ECTS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Course coordinator  | Anna Martonfi, <a href="mailto:a.martonfi@vu.nl">a.martonfi@vu.nl</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Lecturers           | Anna Martonfi, <a href="mailto:a.martonfi@vu.nl">a.martonfi@vu.nl</a><br>Eilidh Webster, <a href="mailto:e.a.webster@vu.nl">e.a.webster@vu.nl</a><br>Alison McRae, <a href="mailto:a.m.mcrae@vu.nl">a.m.mcrae@vu.nl</a><br>Adam Frick, <a href="mailto:a.j.frick@vu.nl">a.j.frick@vu.nl</a><br>Alessandro Cangelli, <a href="mailto:a.cangelli@vu.nl">a.cangelli@vu.nl</a><br>Paul Robertson, <a href="mailto:p.robertson@vu.nl">p.robertson@vu.nl</a> |
| Level               | 100                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Office hours        | by appointment only                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Form of instruction | Lectures and seminars                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Target group        | First year students of Artificial Intelligence                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Other information   | This is an obligatory course in the first-year programme                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

### 2. COURSE READING

Required:

1. Feedback website for Academic English: <http://www2.fgw.vu.nl/els-online/>

Recommended background readings:

2. M. Hannay & J.L. Mackenzie, *Effective Writing in English* (3rd edition). 2017. Bussum: Coutinho.
3. Hilary Glasman-Deal, *Science Research Writing for non-native speakers of English*. 2010. London: Imperial College Press.
4. Janene van Loon, Arnoud Thuss, Nicole Schmidt, and Kevin Haines, *Academic Writing in English, a Process-based Approach*. 2011. Bussum: Coutinho.
5. Academic Phrasebank (University of Manchester):  
<http://www.phrasebank.manchester.ac.uk/>

### 3. CANVAS

Most materials for this course (powerpoints, guidelines for assignments) as well as assignments and individual feedback will be made available on the course's Canvas

site. You will also be asked to submit your assignments via Canvas. Make sure you check the pages regularly and keep an eye on announcements.

#### 4. ATTENDANCE

Attendance is obligatory (80% minimum) and students are expected to actively participate during sessions. If you miss more than two sessions then you may be allowed to continue the course if you submit an alternative assignment that will be determined by the seminar teacher. Students who miss more than three sessions or who fail to submit an adequate alternative assignment will be excluded from the final assignment and also from the resit. These consequences are serious, so please make sure you do indeed comply with these requirements and get in touch with your seminar teacher in case of any problems.

#### 5. AIMS OF THE COURSE

The aim of this course are to improve your academic writing skills. More specifically, you will:

- gain insight into the specific characteristics of formal written English;
- learn the conventions of using sources through quoting, referring and paraphrasing;
- develop your academic skills with regard to text structure, linguistic accuracy, and clarity of expression.

In addition, you will be able to apply this knowledge by writing a text about an academic topic, which uses academic sources appropriately; has no major grammatical errors; uses a clear text structure; and has a style which is suitable for academic texts.

#### 6. COURSE SCHEDULE

| Week | Lecture                                                           | Seminar                                                                  | Assignment deadlines             |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 1    | 'Why Academic English?':<br>Introduction to Academic Writing      | Dos and don't's in academic writing<br>Introductory writing exercise     |                                  |
| 2    | 'I want to tell you something':<br>The structure of introductions | Structure: Introductions<br>Language: Grammar issues                     | Friday 11 April:<br>assignment 1 |
| 3    | 'Standing on the shoulders of giants':<br>Quoting and referring   | Structure: Use of sources<br>Language: Summarizing and paraphrasing      |                                  |
| 4    | 'Writing with hamburgers':<br>Paragraph structure                 | Structure: Paragraphs<br>Language: Linking language and clause combining | Friday 25 April:<br>assignment 2 |
| 5    | NO CLASS                                                          | NO CLASS                                                                 |                                  |

|   |                                                    |                                                 |                             |
|---|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| 6 | 'The take-home message': How to write a conclusion | Structure: Conclusions<br>Language: Punctuation | Friday 9 May: assignment 3  |
| 7 | 'Dressing for the occasion': Academic Style        | Structure: Text Plans<br>Language: Formality    |                             |
| 8 | NO CLASS                                           | NO CLASS                                        | Friday 23 May: assignment 4 |

## 7. COURSE CONTENT

In the course, we will focus on generic skills that are relevant for academic writing: creating an appropriate formal style and using standard academic phrases and creating a clear structure for your text. You will write a text about a topic from your discipline, based on academic sources, using a referencing style that is standard in your discipline. We will also pay attention to general principles of good writing, such as guiding the reader through the text and creating a good flow in the text. We will address these topics in such a way that you will be able to apply these principles in any text that you write after following the course.

In addition, you will get individual feedback on your own texts, which will allow you to gain insight into your own strengths and weaknesses in terms of linguistic accuracy (grammar, punctuation, spelling and vocabulary).

The subjects covered are the following:

- Academic style: formality, use of academic phrases
- Quoting, referring and avoiding plagiarism
- Structure: introduction, thesis statement, paragraph structure, conclusion
- Linguistic accuracy: grammar, vocabulary and punctuation
- Clarity of formulation: linking language, clause combining

## 9. ASSIGNMENTS AND FINAL ASSESSMENT

The final assignment for this course is a 1000-word paper on a topic of your choice, based on 2-5 academic articles. There are some suggested articles on Canvas, but you can also choose your own articles, as long as you make sure that they are published academic articles. In order to get there, there are three assignments where we work towards the final text.

Assignment 1, Three-sentence introduction

1. Write a 3-sentence 'elevator pitch' to introduce what you want to write your final essay on according to the format explained in class. The aim of this assignment is to start the process of thinking about the articles, and to check if academic formality and accuracy work efficiently in your writing.
2. Choose according to your interest, because this is the topic you will be working with for the rest of the course.

3. The text will be graded on the following aspects:
  - Structure: format of the three-sentence introduction
  - Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic idiom
  - Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
4. If you get a fail, you will need to hand in a new version within a couple of days.

#### Assignment 2, Introduction and first body paragraph

1. Develop your 3-sentence 'elevator pitch' into a full introduction, and write up the first body paragraph of your essay.
2. The text should be written in a third-person perspective (Smith describes, concludes, points out etc.)
3. Apart from the introduction and first body paragraph, write a few sentences each on (i) how you plan to develop the paper further, and (ii) on what you want to learn from this assignment. You can include one or two specific aspects you want feedback on in particular from your instructor.
4. The text should contain 400 words with a 10% margin, references and reflection excluded.
5. The text will be graded on the following aspects:
  - Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
  - Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic idiom
  - Use of sources: indication and incorporation of sources in the text; use of referencing style; no traces of plagiarism
6. If you get a grade below 5.5, you will need to hand in a new version within a couple of days.

#### Assignment 3, Three-sentence conclusion

1. Write a 3-sentence conclusion to your final essay according to the format explained in class.
2. The assignment will be graded on the following aspects:
  - Structure: format of the three-sentence conclusion
  - Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic idiom
  - Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
3. If you get a fail, you will need to hand in a new version within a couple of days.

#### Assignment 4, Final paper

1. Write a 1000-word essay (plus or minus 10%) on a topic of your own choice, related to your academic discipline. The aim of the final assignment is to see how you've developed your ideas into a full essay, and to see how the structure, quoting and referring conventions, academic style, clarity and accuracy of your writing have progressed, including whether you took feedback from the first two assignments on board.
2. Use 2-5 academic articles. You can use articles you have selected yourself, or you can use the database on Canvas.
3. Make sure you incorporate feedback from the first three assignments.

4. Write a few sentences of reflection, linking this to the reflection you included in Assignment 2. You can include one or two specific aspects you want feedback on from your instructor.
5. Your assignment will be graded on the following aspects:
  - Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
  - Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic idiom
  - Structure: intro, body, conclusion and a thesis statement covering the content of the entire essay; paragraph structure: topic sentence + elaboration
  - Use of sources: indication and incorporation of sources in the text; use of referencing style; no traces of plagiarism
  - Clarity of expression: linking language, clause combining.
6. Late submissions will not be graded and you will have to wait until the resit date [t.b.a.].

## **10. REPAIRS AND RESITS**

If you fail the final assignment, then you will be informed whether you need to do some limited but essential repair work to get a pass or whether a more substantial reworking is necessary. In the most extreme case you may be required to write a new text. Your seminar teacher will inform you of the new deadline for the repaired text.

Please note that you may be given a fail/repair task even though your text is in general a good text. A repair task may, for instance, be the result of the lack of a title or bibliography.

## **11. ORIGINALITY**

The assignment you submit must be your own work. You cannot even take sentences or parts of sentences from other sources without specifying what those sources are. Advice on how to use sources and how to paraphrase what other people have said will be given during the course and you should follow the guidelines from your own programme of study. All assignments will be checked using plagiarism software. Plagiarism is a serious business, and is regarded as an academic offence. If it turns out that you have committed plagiarism, you will be invited for a meeting with your seminar teacher, who is obliged to inform your examination board about all serious cases. Examination boards across the university have adopted their own measures for dealing with plagiarism.

The recent advancements in AI technology have complicated the issue of originality in student writing. In this course, you are not allowed to use AI tools to generate content or text, not even for individual sentences. You are allowed to use AI tools as editorial aids within certain limits. This means that you can use AI tools to improve a sentence that you have first written yourself. You are asked to be transparent about their use of AI and to indicate the ways in which it has been used in their writing. In the course, we aim to help students better understand the way AI tools work; the ethical considerations around using these tools; the limitations of AI tools; and the ways that AI tools, such as ChatGPT, can assist in the writing process. Ultimately, students are responsible for the

correctness, coherence, and clarity of all texts they submit in the course. You can address any specific questions to your seminar teacher.

## **12. USE OF STUDENT WORK**

For research and teaching purposes, we would like to ask all students to sign a consent form giving permission to use their texts for analysis. The consent form, which will be handed out in class and will be available on Canvas, can be handed in to the course lecture.